

**Successful feeding** A correct latch on ensures your baby is fed efficiently and will feel most comfortable for you.

**Space under the nose** Your baby's nostrils are clear of the breast so that she can breathe easily.

**Ear and jaw movement** Look for the correct muscle movements in her face.

### IS SHE WELL LATCHED ON?

Make sure your baby's bottom lip is curled backward, with her chin resting on your breast; her nose is free so that she can breathe easily; her lower lip covers more of the areola than her upper lip. She will settle into a rhythmic sucking-swallow pattern. Her bottom jaw and ears will move as she nurses. You may hear swallowing noises and lip smacking. When she comes off the breast, your nipple shouldn't look compressed.

### SIGNS OF A POOR LATCH

A little discomfort is normal at the beginning of a feeding, but this shouldn't persist, and you shouldn't feel pain. A clicking noise also indicates that your baby isn't latched on properly since this is produced when your baby sucks only on the nipple.

**Nipple position** Her mouth covers the areola so she isn't sucking only on the nipple.

### TAKING HER OFF THE BREAST

If the latch doesn't feel right, don't continue feeding. Gently break the suction by putting your little finger into the corner of your baby's mouth, and start again. Don't remove her without breaking the suction since this will pull on your nipple.

## EARLY HUNGER SIGNS

It will be much harder to latch on a hungry baby, so learn to read her hunger cues:

- » Her eyelids flutter as she stirs from sleep.
- » She opens and closes her mouth and may make sucking actions and stick out her tongue.
- » She puts her hand to her mouth and may suck it.
- » She clenches her fist.
- » She turns her head side to side and "roots" or nuzzles toward your nipple.
- » She makes jerky leg and arm movements.



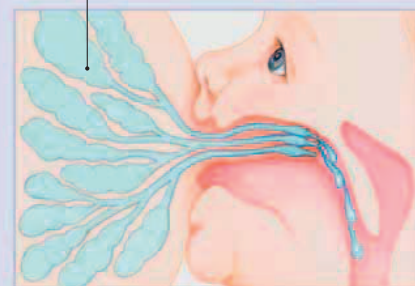
**Tasty hand** If your baby is sucking her hand, it is quite likely she is ready for a feeding.

## THE LETDOWN REFLEX

As your baby starts sucking at your breast, nerves in your nipple are stimulated, which in turn triggers the release of hormones.

The hormone prolactin sends a signal to your breast tissues to produce more milk. The hormone oxytocin stimulates cells in your breast to release milk, which is pushed through the ducts toward the nipple, a process known as the "letdown." This can create a tingling sensation when your baby starts sucking. Some women feel a slight pain that quickly passes, or discomfort and a sensation of pressure.

**Milk ducts** Breast milk is pushed through the ducts



**Milk flow** The milk released by the letdown reflex flows toward the nipple to feed your baby.